

Canning fruits - volunteer facilitation guide

Experienced MFP - live boiling water bath demonstration

Opening safety briefing (read aloud at the start of every demo)

- Wash hands thoroughly before starting.
- Use clean, undamaged jars and follow manufacturer's instructions for lids.
- Avoid burns: handle hot jars and boiling water carefully with protective gloves or jar lifters.
- Always use tested recipes and processing times to prevent foodborne illness.
- Remove jars from hot water carefully to avoid splashing and burns.

Before you start - equipment setup

- Canning jars (pint or quart size, straight-sided recommended)
- Two-piece canning lids (flat lid and screw band)
- Large pot or boiling water canner with rack
- Jar lifter or tongs
- Ladle and funnel
- Wide spatula or plastic knife to remove air bubbles
- Clean towels or cloths
- Pot for heating syrup or water
- Timer or clock
- Heat-resistant gloves or mitts

Narrated demonstration - say the WHY, not just the what

1. Prepare fruit: Wash fruit thoroughly. Peel, core, pit, slice, or halve as appropriate. To prevent darkening, soak cut fruit in ascorbic acid solution or anti-darkening product. Drain just before packing.
Why: Cleaning removes dirt and microbes; peeling and slicing prepare the fruit for packing. Ascorbic acid prevents enzymatic browning that affects color and quality.
Tell your audience: Handle knives carefully; avoid cross-contamination by washing hands and surfaces.
2. Prepare jars and lids: Wash jars in hot soapy water and rinse. Keep jars hot until ready to fill, either in hot water or in a warm oven. Prepare lids according to manufacturer's directions (usually simmering in hot water, not boiling).
Why: Hot jars reduce the risk of breakage and help maintain food temperature during filling and processing, which improves seal quality.
Tell your audience: Avoid sudden temperature changes to prevent jar breakage.
3. Choose packing method - hot pack or raw pack: Hot pack means heating fruit in boiling syrup, water or juice before packing; raw pack means packing raw fruit into jars and covering with boiling liquid.
Why: Hot packing helps expel air, shrinks fruit to prevent floating, and reduces processing time. Raw pack is quicker but may result in more floating fruit.
Tell your audience: Be cautious with hot liquids to prevent burns.
4. Prepare syrup or liquid: Prepare light, medium, or heavy syrup (as desired) by dissolving sugar in water and bringing it to a boil. Use syrup, water, or fruit juice to cover fruit in jars.
Why: Syrup preserves flavor and texture; boiling liquid helps kill microbes and pack fruit safely.
Tell your audience: Handle boiling liquids carefully.
5. Fill jars with fruit and cover with boiling syrup, water, or juice leaving appropriate headspace (usually 1/2 inch).
Why: Proper headspace allows for expansion during processing and vacuum seal formation.
Tell your audience: Use a funnel and handle jars carefully to avoid spills.
6. Remove air bubbles by sliding a plastic spatula or blunt knife along the inside edges of the jar.
Why: Removing air bubbles prevents trapped air that can cause spoilage or poor seals.

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Tell your audience: Avoid using metal knives to prevent jar damage.

7. Wipe jar rims with a clean damp cloth to remove any residue.

Why: Ensures a clean sealing surface for lids to adhere properly.

Tell your audience: Use clean cloths to avoid contamination.

8. Apply lids and screw on screw bands fingertip tight (not too tight).

Why: Allows air to escape during processing for proper vacuum sealing when cooling.

Tell your audience: Do not overtighten lids to avoid lid damage and poor seal.

9. Process jars in a boiling water canner: Place jars on rack in the canner with at least 1 inch of water above jars. Bring water to a full rolling boil and process for the time specified by fruit type, jar size, and altitude (e.g., 20-30 minutes for apples or peaches).

Why: Boiling water kills harmful microorganisms and creates vacuum seals as jars cool.

Tell your audience: Use jar lifter to handle hot jars; avoid water splashing.

10. After processing time, turn off heat and remove canner lid. Wait 5 minutes before removing jars from water.

Why: Prevents sudden temperature changes that could cause jar breakage or seal failure.

Tell your audience: Be cautious of steam when removing lid.

11. Remove jars using jar lifter and place on towel or rack to cool undisturbed for 12-24 hours.

Why: Cooling allows vacuum seals to form and stabilizes the product.

Tell your audience: Do not retighten lids or disturb jars while cooling.

12. Check seals: Press the center of each lid; it should be concave and not flex up and down. Remove screw bands and try to lift the lid with fingertips to confirm seal.

Why: Ensures that jars are properly sealed and product is safe for storage. Unsealed jars should be refrigerated and used promptly or reprocessed.

Tell your audience: Discard jars with bulging lids or signs of spoilage.

Common questions (OSU-sourced answers)

Q: Can I use less sugar when canning fruit?

A: Fruits may be canned safely with reduced sugar or even with no sugar added using plain water. No adjustments are needed in the processing time, but absence of sugar may result in softer texture and less flavor. For jams and jellies, regular pectin products do not allow sugar reduction unless specified. Low- or no-sugar needed pectin varieties can be used for low-sugar or no-sugar jams or jellies. Reduced sugar in jams/jellies may result in a syrupy consistency; special pectins or alternative sweeteners should be used following manufacturer directions. Sugar is not necessary to prevent spoilage and can be omitted by replacing sugar syrup with water or unsweetened juice for canning fruits. Other sweeteners like honey or corn syrup can substitute some sugar but affect flavor and sweetness levels. Sucralose (Splenda) is heat stable and may be added before canning; other artificial sweeteners are best added after opening.

Source: SP 50 646 Preserving for special diets

Q: Do I have to use a rack for canning?

A: Use a rack in the canner to keep jars off the bottom of the pan and prevent heat damage during processing. Use a canning rack or a substitute that allows water to circulate freely around the jars for even heat distribution and safe processing.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

Q: How do I know a jar sealed?

A: After processing and cooling, jars that are sealed will have lids concave and will not flex up and down when pressed. Remove the ring band and test the seal by gently lifting the jar by the lid; properly sealed lids remain firmly attached. If the lid can be pressed or flexes, the jar is not sealed.

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Source: SP 50 646 Preserving for special diets

Q: Can I reuse canning lids?

A: Canning lids are designed for one-time use only and should not be reused. Always use new, properly prepared lids for each canning session to ensure a safe seal.

Source: SP 50 646 Preserving for special diets

Q: What if my lid did not seal?

A: If jars do not seal after processing, the food may be refrigerated and consumed within a certain time, or re-processed using new lids within 24 hours following safe canning procedures. Alternatively, the unsealed jars can be frozen or refrigerated and used promptly. Discard jars if spoilage is evident.

Source: SP 50 646 Preserving for special diets

Cleanup

- Turn off heat and unplug equipment once cool.
- Wash and dry all equipment; store jars in a cool, dark place.
- Label sealed jars with contents and date; refrigerate any unsealed jars.

Sources

Every value above is drawn from these OSU/USDA Extension publications. Verify against the cited source before public use.

- EM 9446 Playing it safe when preserving elderberries
- PNW 199 Canning fruits
- SP 50 444 Preserving peaches
- SP 50 586 Preserving plums and prunes
- SP 50 646 Preserving for special diets
- SP 50 678 Preserving pears
- SP 50 757 Fruit pickles chutney
- SP 50 780 Preserving berries
- SP 50 883 Preserving cherries